

ALL THE QUEEN'S MEN

Pratibha Patil, the first woman to become President of India, defeated her nearest rival Bhairon Singh Shekhawat by over 3,00,000 votes in July. With the BJP accusing Sonia of appointing "loyalists" to the country's top post, the prestige of the Congress president was at stake. Sonia took a personal interest in the campaign, meeting MPs and coaching them on how to sign the ballot paper. As Patil was the first choice, Congress MPs were told that they had to write the numerical figure '1'—or, like "Gandhiji's lathi", as Sonia told an MP from Gujarat.



SIPRA DAS

“Now that women are progressing in every field, we should morally support and encourage them to leave such practices (purdah) behind.”

PRATIBHA PATIL, PRESIDENT OF INDIA